

Higher National Diploma in Tourism and Hospitality Management
Assignment – Sri Lankan Studies(SLS) THM11042
First Year First Semester



Sri Lanka Institute of Advanced Technological Education– Dehiwala

DEH/THM/2025/F/0023
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A Historical Analysis of Colonial Sri Lanka (1505–1948) (PORTUGUESE, DUTCH, AND BRITISH PERIODS)

1. Introduction

Sri Lanka, known variously throughout history as *Taprobane*, *Serendib*, *Ceilão*, and *Ceylon*, has always held a position of supreme strategic importance in the Indian Ocean. Situated at the midpoint of the maritime Silk Road connecting the Occident and the Orient, the island was a hub for traders from Rome, Arabia, and China long before the arrival of European powers. However, the period commencing in the early 16th century marked a definitive rupture in the island's historical trajectory. For nearly 450 years, from 1505 to 1948, Sri Lanka was subjected to the colonial ambitions of three distinct European powers: the Portuguese, the Dutch, and the British.

This era, often referred to as the "Colonial Period," was not merely a change in political leadership but a fundamental restructuring of the island's economy, society, and culture. The Portuguese and Dutch periods were characterized by the control of the maritime provinces and a mercantilist focus on the spice trade, specifically cinnamon. In contrast, the British period witnessed the complete political unification of the island, the fall of the indigenous Kandyan Kingdom, and the integration of Ceylon into the global capitalist market through a plantation economy. This assignment provides a comprehensive historical analysis of these three periods, examining the specific mechanisms of control, economic exploitation, and the lasting legacies that shaped modern Sri Lanka.

2. The Portuguese Period (1505–1658): The Era of the Sword and the Cross

The arrival of the Portuguese in 1505 was a serendipitous event driven by the vagaries of weather. A fleet commanded by Lourenço de Almeida, seeking Maldives ships, was blown off course to the harbor of Galle. Upon realizing the island was the fabled source of high-quality cinnamon, the Portuguese objective shifted from exploration to domination, guided by their imperial motto: "God, Gold, and Glory."

2.1 Political Fragmentation and Manipulation

At the time of the Portuguese arrival, Sri Lanka was politically fragmented. The island was divided into three main kingdoms: the Kingdom of Kotte (the nominal overlord), the Kingdom of Kandy in the highlands, and the Kingdom of Jaffna in the north. The Portuguese skillfully exploited these internal divisions.

Their primary strategy was to embed themselves in the politics of the Kotte Kingdom. By promising military protection to the weak King Bhuvanekabahu VII against his brother Mayadunne of Sitawaka, the Portuguese gained a foothold in Colombo. This relationship culminated in the conversion of Bhuvanekabahu's grandson, Dharmapala, to Catholicism. Taking the name Don Juan Dharmapala, he became a puppet ruler. In a historic act of submission, he formally bequeathed the Kingdom of Kotte to the Portuguese Crown by a deed of gift in 1580. Thus, by 1597, upon Dharmapala's death, the King of Portugal became the legal sovereign of the maritime provinces.

2.2 Military Conflict and the Sitawaka Resistance

The Portuguese era was defined by incessant warfare. The Kingdom of Sitawaka, led by the warrior king Mayadunne and later his son Rajasinghe I, posed the fiercest resistance. The Battle of Mulleriyawa (1562) stands out as a significant event where the Portuguese suffered one of their worst defeats in Asia at the hands of the Sinhalese armies. However, the Portuguese superiority in naval power and artillery,

combined with their construction of fortified garrisons along the coast, allowed them to hold the maritime belt despite constant inland raids.

2.3 The Spiritual Conquest

Perhaps the most enduring legacy of the Portuguese was their religious policy. Unlike the Dutch and British, who were primarily motivated by commerce, the Portuguese viewed colonization as a crusade. Missionaries from the Franciscan, Jesuit, Dominican, and Augustinian orders arrived to convert the local population.

This "spiritual conquest" was often aggressive. Buddhist temples and Hindu kovils were destroyed to make way for churches. However, the Portuguese also offered significant social mobility to converts, which led to a large section of the Karava, Salagama, and Durava castes in the coastal belt embracing Catholicism. This created a permanent Catholic community in Sri Lanka, introducing Portuguese surnames like Perera, Silva, De Soya, and Fernando, which remain ubiquitous today.

3. The Dutch Period (1658–1796): The Mercantile Administration

By the early 17th century, the Kandyan Kingdom, now the sole bastion of Sinhalese independence, sought to expel the Portuguese. King Rajasinghe II of Kandy turned to the rising naval power of the Dutch East India Company (*Vereenigde Oostindische Compagnie* or VOC). This alliance proved to be a fatal diplomatic error, famously described in the Sinhalese proverb as "giving ginger and taking chili" (*Inguru deela miris gaththa wage*).

3.1 The Betrayal and Establishment of Monopoly

The Dutch captured Colombo in 1656 and Jaffna in 1658, finally expelling the Portuguese. However, instead of handing the coastal forts back to the Kandyan King as promised, the VOC retained them, claiming the King owed them immense war debts. The VOC was not a state but a joint-stock company; their primary motivation was profit. They established a strict monopoly over the cinnamon trade. Under Dutch law, peeling cinnamon without permission was a capital offense punishable by death. They organized the *Salagama* caste specifically for cinnamon peeling duties, turning it into a compulsory state service (*Rajakariya*).

3.2 Administrative and Legal Reforms

While the Portuguese ruled through military might, the Dutch ruled through administration. They realized that a stable colony was a profitable one.

- **Roman-Dutch Law:** Their most significant contribution was the introduction of a formal legal system. The Roman-Dutch Law was applied to the Low Country Sinhalese and remains the basis of Sri Lanka's general law today, particularly regarding property and delicts.
- **The Thombu System:** To maximize tax collection, the Dutch compiled detailed land registries called *Thombus*. This was the first systematic attempt at land registration in the island's history.

3.3 Economic Infrastructure and Agriculture

The Dutch were pragmatic agriculturalists. Realizing that rice had to be imported, they encouraged paddy cultivation in the lowlands. More importantly, they built an extensive network of canals (e.g., the

Hamilton Canal and the Dutch Canal in Negombo) to transport cinnamon and timber from the interior to the ports. They also introduced new crops such as coffee, pepper, and coconut on a plantation scale, laying the groundwork for the export economy that the British would later perfect.

3.4 The Burghers

The Dutch period led to the creation of a distinct ethnic community known as the Burghers—descendants of unions between Dutch VOC employees and local women. The Burghers became a vital part of the colonial administration, serving as intermediaries, clerks, and later, legal professionals. Their cultural legacy persists in Sri Lankan cuisine (Lamprais, Breudher), furniture, and architecture (the Galle Fort).

4. The British Period (1796–1948): Unification and the Plantation Economy

The British arrival was triggered by the Napoleonic Wars in Europe. When the Netherlands fell to France, Britain feared that the vital harbor of Trincomalee would fall into French hands. To prevent this, they seized the Dutch possessions in Ceylon in 1796. Initially, the island was administered by the British East India Company from Madras, but the mismanagement led to a rebellion in 1797. Consequently, in 1802, Ceylon was made a Crown Colony, directly responsible to the Colonial Office in London.

4.1 The Fall of Kandy and Unification (1815)

The British achieved what the Portuguese and Dutch could not: the conquest of the entire island. They realized that military invasions of Kandy were costly and often failed due to guerilla warfare and the difficult terrain. Instead, Governor Robert Brownrigg utilized espionage and diplomacy. Exploiting the growing rift between the tyrannical King Sri Wickrama Rajasinghe and his feudal chiefs (*Adigars*), the British presented themselves as "liberators."

In 1815, the **Kandyan Convention** was signed. This treaty deposed the King and ceded the sovereignty of the Kandyan Kingdom to the British Crown, with the promise that Buddhism and customary laws would be protected. This ended over 2,300 years of indigenous monarchy and brought the entire island under a single administration. However, the British quickly disregarded the treaty's clauses, leading to the **Great Rebellion of 1818** (Uva-Wellassa Uprising). The British crushed this rebellion with a "scorched earth" policy, decimating the agricultural base of the Uva province.

4.2 The Plantation Raj

The British transformed Sri Lanka from a feudal agrarian society into a capitalist plantation economy.

- **Coffee:** In the 1830s, the British discovered that the central highlands were ideal for coffee. To acquire land, they passed the **Crown Lands (Encroachments) Ordinance of 1840**, often called the "Waste Lands Ordinance." This law declared that all uncultivated land belonged to the Crown, effectively stripping Kandyan peasants of their traditional chena (slash-and-burn) lands.
- **Tea:** Following the destruction of the coffee industry by the *Hemileia vastatrix* fungus in the 1870s, the British successfully switched to Tea. "Ceylon Tea" became a global brand.
- **Indentured Labor:** The Sinhalese peasants were unwilling to work as wage laborers on plantations under harsh conditions. Consequently, the British imported hundreds of thousands of Tamil coolies from South India. This demographic engineering created the "Indian Tamil" community in the hill country, distinct from the indigenous Jaffna Tamils.

4.3 Infrastructure and Modernization

To extract resources efficiently, the British revolutionized the island's infrastructure.

- **Roads and Railways:** The Colombo-Kandy road was completed by Captain Dawson, and the railway line reached Kandy in 1867. These engineering marvels were built primarily to transport coffee and tea to the Colombo port, but they also integrated the remote interior with the capital.
- **Education and the Elite:** The Colebrooke-Cameron Reforms of 1833 established English as the language of administration. Missionary schools (such as Royal College, S. Thomas', and Trinity) produced a Westernized, English-speaking local elite. This class, comprised of Sinhalese, Tamils, and Burghers, eventually led the constitutional struggle for independence.

4.4 The Path to Independence

Unlike neighboring India, Sri Lanka's path to independence was largely peaceful and constitutional. The temperance movement in the early 20th century transformed into a political struggle. Leaders like D.S. Senanayake, F.R. Senanayake, and Sir Ponnambalam Ramanathan negotiated for greater autonomy. The **Donoughmore Constitution of 1931** was a landmark event, granting Universal Adult Franchise—Sri Lanka was one of the first non-white colonies to receive this right. Finally, on February 4, 1948, Ceylon was granted dominion status, ending British rule.

5. Conclusion

The analysis of the period from 1505 to 1948 reveals that the Portuguese, Dutch, and British occupations were not merely interludes but foundational epochs that constructed modern Sri Lanka.

The **Portuguese** broke the island's isolation, linking it to the West and leaving a permanent religious legacy in Roman Catholicism. The **Dutch** incorporated the island into a formal legal framework and developed the first systematic export agriculture. The **British**, however, had the most profound impact. They unified the political geography, dismantled the feudal land tenure system, and replaced it with a capitalist plantation economy.

However, this development came at a cost. The plantation economy made Sri Lanka dependent on volatile global markets. The import of labor and the "divide and rule" administrative tactics exacerbated ethnic fault lines. The English-educated elite became disconnected from the vernacular-speaking masses, creating a class divide that would plague the country post-independence. Thus, the colonial experience was a double-edged sword: it modernized Sri Lanka's infrastructure and administration, but it bequeathed a complex set of economic and social challenges that the independent nation continues to navigate in the 21st century.

6. References

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